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From the editor-in-chief

The trial of the man who has come to symbolise the worst face of terror, Ajmal Kasab, is over. The guilty verdict was expected but what is a revelation is the body of evidence—part of the 1,522-page judgement delivered by Justice M.L. Tahaliyani—in the chargesheet presented by the Mumbai Police which investigated the 60-hour killing spree by Kasab and his nine fellow terrorists that left 166 people dead. Tahaliyani referred to the attack and its perpetrators as “no ordinary criminals but an act of war”. The judgement found Kasab guilty on over 80 counts but the ones that matter are conspiracy to wage war against the state and waging war against the state.

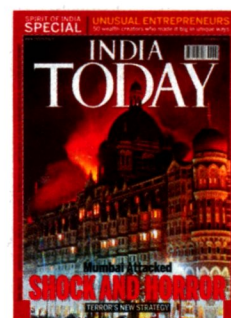
What has emerged from the chargesheet is a comprehensive account of the entire conspiracy, starting from when it was hatched in Pakistan by the Lashkar-e-Toiba, the recruitment, special training and the cold-blooded manner in which it was planned and executed. The exhaustive chargesheet contains the full and final investigation into 26/11. What it also does is nail the Pakistan connection in irrefutable detail, including the key conspirators. The Pakistan connection in the chargesheet is quite damaging and includes quite a few new facts that were uncovered in the investigation. With the active help of the FBI and American agencies, investigators traced the engine of the inflatable dinghy used by the terrorists to a firm in Lahore. The hand grenades used were manufactured by a Pakistan ordnance factory located near Islamabad and were similar to the ones used in the serial bomb blasts in Mumbai in 1993 as also in the attack on Indian Parliament in December 2001. There are other bits of evidence that testify to the extent of the conspiracy as well as the incredible effort that has gone into the investigation.

The chargesheet provides details of the training camps, the names of the conspirators as well as the trainers and details the military precision with which the attacks were planned, conclusively pointing to training by military professionals in Pakistan. The FBI also helped in tracing mobile phones and conversations between the terrorists in Mumbai and their handlers in Pakistan, along with money transfers.

The real core of the chargesheet lies in retracing the bloody trail that Kasab and his partner left behind till they were finally stopped. In fact, the investigation reveals how Kasab was recruited, initially for money to escape extreme poverty and how he later turned into a killer consumed not so much by jihadi ideology but plain bloodlust. The story of his bloody rampage and capture is given in much greater detail than has come out so far. Kasab heard the guilty verdict without showing any emotion or remorse, an indication of how Pakistan's jihadi factory can brainwash youngsters like him so easily.

Sadly, there is much cannon fodder like Kasab in Pakistan for the masterminds of 26/11 to feed on for their evil designs. Such jihadis are mere dispensable pawns in the hands of the real conspirators, Hafiz Saeed and Zaki-ur-Rehman Lakhvi who still roam free in Pakistan, thanks to that government's characteristic blind eye to terror attacks in India. Till people like them are brought to justice, there is little hope for terror strikes to end, and closure for the relatives of the 166 hapless victims of 26/11 will not happen.

(Aroon Purie)



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